TUSHAR TANKARIA



CHANDUBHAI VIRANI, 65, **& BROTHERS**

Rajkot, Gujarat

Company

Balaji Wafers Pvt Ltd

Net Worth

Rs 9,200 crore

Crisp Kings

In the 1970s, before the Narmada waters reached the parched lands of Saurashtra, many farmers migrated to towns. In 1972, Popat Ramjibhai Virani gave Rs 20,000 each to his three sons—Bhikhu, Chandu and Kanu—after selling his farmland in Dhundoraji village in Jamnagar district. Chandu migrated to Rajkot, where he got a job at the Astron cinema house. A year later, the brothers bagged the contract to operate the cinema canteen. Their most popular snack were the potato wafers. Since the supplier would delay delivery, they decided to make it themselves. With an investment of Rs 10,000, Chandubhai set up a workshop. "If staff didn't turn up, I fried the wafers. We did everything ourselves," he says. In 1984, they named their brand Balaji Wafers. The next 20 years were tough, but "we remained resilient", founder-director Chandubhai adds. Spiced with desi masalas, the crisps are a match with the Indian palate.

Balaji's distribution network is unique. "It's like a cooperative. We pay attention to small distributors. We just focus on quality and packaging," Chandubhai says. In 2013, the Viranis turned down takeover bids from several multinational firms. Balaji was valued at Rs 1,200 crore then, and the buyout offer was of Rs 4,000 crore. A decade later, the company's revenue is Rs 4,000 crore and its valuation estimated five times as much. "Our plan is to expand and widen our snacks portfolio. Today, we have 7,000 employees, 3,000 suppliers, three factories. Our products are available in 24 countries and 15 states, with 1,500 dealers reaching 2 million shops," Chandubhai says. All thanks to the humble wafer.

-Jumana Shah



SUBHAS M. KAMATH, 57

Udupi, Karnataka

Company

Abharan Jewellers

Net worth of the Kamaths

Rs 1,900 crore

MAN WITH THE GOLDEN TOUCH

Where he invests profits
Back into business. "It has paid off well," says Subhas